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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' directing Minister Prakash Jwala and the officials of the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport in Singha Durbar, Kathmandu on Thursday.

My address will be implemented in letter and spirit: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the address to the nation he delivered on Tuesday would function as a roadmap for the government in the coming year and promised to implement it in word and spirit.

In a discussion he held with Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport Prakash Jwala and other officials of the ministry at his office on Thursday, Prime Minister Prachanda told everyone to understand the address he delivered and informed them that their work would be reviewed.

"I may have been a bit too generous. I left the ministry to work on its own but I deem this may not have delivered the expected results," he said, adding, "We are restructuring the Prime Minister's Office today. Other tasks will also be taken forward gradually. Every letter of the address will be implemented."

He also asked the ministry officials not to consider Thursday's meeting an ordinary one. "This discussion is aimed at bringing a new momentum to our work. This is the beginning, not the end," he said.

At the meeting, Minister Jwala informed the Prime Minister that his ministry had prioritised the construction of the Mugling-Pokhara and Narayangadh-Butwal roads. He also said that work on the Nagdhunga Tunnel construction project was moving ahead as expected.

Jwala further said that they were focused on expanding and blacktopping roads in Simikot, Humla and assured that all dues of all contractors would be cleared.

At the same time, Minister Jwala urged for the adoption of a flexible process to ensure resources for infrastructure projects and design programmes to ensure national pride projects do not face a budget crunch. He also called for the formulation of an umbrella act or the development of a high-level mechanism to address problems seen in infrastructure projects.

The Minister further stated that several projects were facing a shortage of funds in absence of budget transfer.

At the discussion, Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha, Vice Chairman of National Planning Commission, highlighted the need to set up a 'Prime Minister Delivery Unit.'

Among other things, the Prime Minister instructed the ministry to identify accident-prone roads and repair them to make them safer. He also asked the gathered officials to pay special attention to the Postal Highway, Mid-Hill Highway, Madan Bhandari Highway and strategic roads that connect the country's northern regions with the southern ones.

He also asked the ministry to make arrangements to give citizens their driving licences without delays.

PMO TO SLASH 68 STAFF POSITIONS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

The government has decided to restructure the Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers (OPMCM) by approving the Organisation and Management (O&M) survey.

The government fixes support price of wheat at Rs. 3,650 per quintal.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held in Singha Durbar on Thursday afternoon decided to downsize the number of employees at the Office of Prime Ministers and Council of Ministers by cutting 68 posts. PM Prachanda in his address to the nation on Tuesday had shown his intention to bring about structural changes in the Prime Minister's office.

After the Cabinet meeting, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said that with the change in the O&M of the Prime Minister's office, 68 government employees would be reduced by transferring them to other government agencies.

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Notice

There is no Friday Supplement in today's issue of The Rising Nepal.
--Editor

Industry Ministry instructed to prioritise startup venture

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies (MoICS) to give high priority to startup businesses for the youth.

Speaking at a discussion with the officials of the MoICS on Thursday at the Singha Durbar, he directed the Ministry to promote entrepreneurship among young people with innovative thinking and passion, and make preparations to conduct a business promotion campaign focused on seven provinces through the Business Incubation Centre.

"Prepare a special plan to connect the latest ideas of at least 20,000 youths to the production of goods and services by mobilising the startup fund and arrange a 'Jobmeter' to measure the jobs created by self-employed, startups and various businesses," he asked the MoICS.

Emphasising that the diplomatic bodies of the Government of Nepal should focus on the promotion of industry and commerce, PM Prachanda instructed them to go ahead by making necessary plans, mechanisms and programmes for that.

The Prime Minister directed the ministry to prepare a solid framework for sectoral coordination and cooperation to implement the commercial policy, national action plan on trade deficit reduction and National Trade Integration Strategy to implement the basic foundation of "Production and trade: Sustainable basis of all sectoral development".

Likewise, PM Prachanda directed to establish an Industrial Infrastructure Development Facilitation Desk in the Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers and ensure coordination of all sectoral bodies.

To make market monitoring regular and more effective, there is a need to establish and operate an integrated and specialised market monitoring directorate with representation from all relevant bodies, he said while expressing hopes that the ministry would carry out necessary studies on this matter.

Speaking at the meeting, Minister for Industry, Commerce and Supplies, Ramesh Rizal stated that the small amount allocated for the promotion of industry and commerce hindered the implementation of the scheduled programmes and said that an integrated solution should be sought from the government.

Chief Secretary of the Government of Nepal Dr. Baikuntha Aryal said that to make an action plan and implement the issues covered in the Prime Minister's address to the nation was necessary. He also directed the secretaries to prioritise the work of the areas declared as industrial zones.

Likewise, Narayan Prasad Sharma Duwadi, Secretary at the MoICS, presented the status of the ministry, progress, challenges and upcoming programmes.

He said that consistency between new policies, plans, programmes and budgets was necessary, and as inter-agency coordination was not effective, policies and programmes were scattered.

According to him, the Ministry has given priority to the promotion of entrepreneurship, upgrading of micro, cottage and small industries, development of industrial and business infrastructure, capacity building of employees and innovation-oriented programmes.

Emphasising the need to lobby for the promotion of Nepal's industry and commerce in bilateral and multilateral forums, Secretary Duwadi said that the concept of start-up business should be put forward for the youth, deadlines should be set for environmental impact assessment, and programmes run with the Prime Minister's name should be integrated.

Human issues involved in Yeti plane crash: Report



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

The inadvertent movement of both condition levers that resulted in the feathering of propellers likely caused Nepal's deadliest aviation disaster of three decades.

On January 15 this year, an ATR 72-212A aircraft with the registration 9N-ANC operated by Yeti Airlines crashed in Pokhara and killed all 72 people on board. In the aftermath of the crash, the government formed a five-member commission to investigate the incident, determine its causes and present recommendations to prevent similar accidents in the future.

After an 11-month probe, which included analysis of available information and evidence; interviews with concerned individuals; study of reports, records and documents; and preparation and sharing of draft report with concerned states and entities, and incorporating the feedback received, the Commission, led by former secretary at the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation Nagendra Prasad Ghimire, presented its final report to the federal government on Thursday.

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'Regional forums helpful to project national interests'



Minister NP Saud

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

Meaningful affil iation with the regional organisations will be helpful for Nepal to face the challenges it is facing as a landlocked and an underdeveloped country, said Minister for Foreign Affairs NP Saud.

Speaking at a programme organised by the Policy Research Institute (PRI) on the BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) on Thursday in Kathmandu, he stated that Nepal's foreign policy is to promote national interests through the regional forums.

The PRI organised the programme upon the request of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

"Accordingly, Nepal has been active in enhancing mutual cooperation in the economic, social and cultural fields by means of organisations in the Asia region such as the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC), BIMSTEC and Asian Cooperation Dialogue," said FM Saud, adding that Nepal has been giving importance to the BIMSTEC region which connects the countries of South Asia and South East Asia.

It's been 26 years since the establishment of the BIMSTEC. During the initial stage, the forum was used as a movement of cooperation in the areas of mutual interest of the member countries, said FM Saud. The legal, institutional and policy structures are in the process of being prepared after the discussions held during the fourth summit of BIMSTEC held in Kathmandu in 2018.

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Protecting the old, endorsing the new

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

In the first year in office, the Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda'-led government took steps to conserve several traditional water sources of the Kathmandu Valley.

According to the data provided by the Government of Nepal, the present administration has conserved stone spouts (Hitis), ponds and other indigenous sources of water in 20 different locations across the Kathmandu Valley since it assumed office last year.

When contacted, the Ministry of Water Supply informed that this task was performed under the Kathmandu Valley Water Supply Management Board (KVWSMB). The Board could not specify where exactly the 20 conserved water sources were but informed that the work was guided by the status map of Kathmandu's stone spouts and ponds it published in 2019.

As stated in the report, there are 479 stone spouts in existence in the Valley. It also mentions that Kathmandu has 193 ponds. Of them, Santosh Baral, information officer at KVWSMB, told The Rising Nepal that two ponds had been restored in Kirtipur Municipality, Kathmandu, and one in Mahalaxmi Municipality, Lalitpur last year.



PHOTO: MANOJ RATNA SHAHI/TRN

File photo of Tusha Hiti spout at Sundari Chowk, Mangal Bazaar in Lalitpur.

» WATER SOURCE PRESERVATION

The objectives for carrying out these conservation activities, as per the Board, are to protect heritage, maintain groundwater, and promote the socio-cultural aspects related to the ancient water sources.

Meanwhile, figures from the federal government also showed that it installed water vending machines, also known as Water ATMs, in 10 locations, taking the number of such machines operational in the Valley to 31.

KVWSMB informed that these 31 Water ATMs were located at the Shankhadhar Park (Ratnapark), Balaju Park, Bhagwanpau (Swayambhu), Land Revenue Office at Kalanki, Transportation Management Office at Ekantakuna, Baglamukhi Temple, New Baneshwor Chowk, Shankhapark (Dhumbarahi), Nepal Engineering Building (Harihar Bhawan), Patan Hospital, Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital (two ATMs are located here), Bir Hospital, Civil Service Hospital, Bhaktapur Cancer Hospital, District Police Range Office, Teku, Lalitpur Metropolitan City Office, Institute of Engineering, Citizen Investment Trust Office, Patan Mental Hospital, Shahid Gangalal National Heart Centre, Nepal Police Hospital, Kanti Children's Hospital, Bhaktapur Hospital, Suryabinayak Hospital, Tau Daha, Paropakar Maternity and Women's Hospital, Godawari Botanical Garden, Padma Kanya Campus, Kamal Pokhari and Pushpa Lal Park.

The ATMs have an automatic water filtration system and in-built treatment system along with Ultra-Filtration Filter 4040, ozone generator, ultraviolet disinfection, point-of-use filter, back washing system, chilling tank, solar panel, water vending panel, coin changer machine, cup dispenser, water dispenser mechanism and a CCTV camera.

NEA to cut power supply to industries refusing to pay trunk line tariffs: Ghising

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

The Nepal Electricity Authority has made it clear that it has a strategy to cut power supply lines of industries that do not pay electricity arrears under the dedicated feeders and trunk lines.

Organising a press conference on Thursday, Managing Director of NEA Kul Man Ghising said that the NEA would cut the lines of more industries that do not pay electricity dues.

Ghising clarified that it was forced to snap the lines of industries after repeated requests for the payment of electricity tariff, including premium, under the dedicated feeders and trunk lines were ignored.

The NEA has been compelled to cut electricity supplies of industries after they did not show any interest to pay electricity arrears under the dedicated and trunk lines facilities while the NEA repeated requests through public notice, he said.

The Authority has cut the line of nine industries which have huge electricity arrears out of 61 industries which have to settle them.

There is an arrear of Rs. 12.5 billion in the name of those nine industries.

According to the Authority, 61 industries have to pay Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN PHOTO

Managing Director of NEA Kul Man Ghising said that the NEA would cut the lines of more industries that do not pay electricity dues at a press conference, Thursday.

In the past, common consumers experienced load shedding of up to 17/18 hours daily, while 239 industrial, commercial and non-commercial customers were consuming powers for more than 20 hours through dedicated feeders and trunk lines. He said that out of 239 customers, 178 consumers have already paid the electricity tariff to the Authority on time, including the premium for dedicated and trunk lines.

Stating that load shedding was a result of unequal distribution of power, he said, "There was also a voice saying that there was unequal distribution to industrialists and increased power outage to general consumers."

A report prepared by the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation had concluded that there was unequal distribution of electricity in 2070 BS, and there were many complaints even before that.

The Authority started disconnecting the power lines of some industries from Biratnagar on March 18, 2020 after they failed to pay the concessional tariff even after repeated reminders.

However, according to the decision of then Council of Ministers on January 6, 2020, the meeting of the Ministers and Secretaries of the Minister of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation, Ministry of Finance and Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies, taking into account the impact on the overall industry business due to the COVID-19 pandemic, will not cut the power line until further decisions are made in regard to the industries with disputes about dedicated and trunk tariffs.

And the line was reconnected after receiving a decision to send a letter to the Nepal Electricity Authority to restart the service as before, said the NEA.

MD Ghising said that various committees formed to analyse electricity arrears under the dedicated and trunk lines in different dates have recommended collecting arrears from those industries who used electricity through dedicated and trunk lines. "As the NEA is the government's institution, me as MD and other employees of NEA have no right to exempt tariffs to those industries. So, NEA will collect revenue at any cost from these industries," he said.

He said that the objective of the Authority is to collect all fees until the regulatory body decides otherwise.

Ghising clarified that the Auditor General's report in the final audit also pointed out that the Authority should collect the electricity dues.

Ghising said that the data of electricity consumption from dedicated and trunk lines is safe with the NEA.

Industries can pay arrears in instalments

He suggested the industries pay electricity dues based on the bills issued by the NEA in installments.

"We want to request the industries to pay the arrears in installment basis as the NEA is ready to facilitate them," he said.

He suggested the industrialists who have not paid dues to go through the review process.

"By paying a 25 per cent fee, they can go to the review process. Come forth for the review; if you don't like it, there is an option to initiate other processes, including going to the court."

Himalaya Airlines begins Kathmandu-Lhasa flights

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

Himalaya Airlines started Kathmandu-Lhasa-Kathmandu flight service from Thursday, December 28.

The first outbound flight, H9 774, departed from Tribhuvan International Airport at 08:40 am (local time) and reached Lhasa Gonggar Airport, at noon (local time), with a flight duration of one hour and twenty minutes. A total of 136 passengers boarded the first flight, said the company in a statement.

The service will schedule flights every Monday effective from January 01, 2024. This signifies the fifth direct connection Himalaya Airlines has between China and Nepal. The Airlines has been operating flights to Beijing, Chongqing, Qingdao and Shanghai.

"This will mark a significant milestone in Himalaya Airlines' commitment to enhancing connectivity and promoting bilateral ties between Nepal and China," it said in a statement. Himalaya Airlines is a joint venture company with Nepali and Chinese investments.

It said that the Kathmandu-Lhasa-Kathmandu route will offer passengers seamless travel options between the capital city of Nepal with the historically rich and picturesque city of Lhasa.

Lhasa, the capital city of Tibet Autonomous Region in China, is a cultural and spiritual hub in the Himalayas. Known for its breathtaking landscapes and ancient monasteries, Lhasa holds deep significance as the centre of Tibetan Buddhism and Tibetan culture.



PHOTO: TRN

Minister of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation Sudan Kirati initiating Himalaya Airlines Kathmandu-Lhasa-Kathmandu flight service, Thursday.

The inaugural flight event was boarded by Minister for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, Sudan Kirati, and Wang Xin, Deputy Chief of Mission at the Embassy of China in Kathmandu along with other dignitaries.

Minister Kirati said that the newly established route represents a significant advancement in the transportation network linking Nepal and China.

This enhancement in transportation infrastructure not only promotes increased accessibility but also signifies a broader and more diverse network for trade, tourism, and overall bilateral relations between Nepal and China, he said.

Nabil Bank to distribute 11% cash dividend to its' shareholders

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

The 39th Annual General Meeting of Nabil Bank Limited held on Thursday in Kathmandu approved 11 per cent cash dividend to its shareholders. "The AGM has passed the proposal of the bank's Board of Directors to distribute 11 per cent cash dividend from the profit of the last Fiscal Year 2022/23," the bank said in a statement. It earned Rs. 6.4 billion in profits last year.

Chairman of the bank, Upendra Paudyal, said that considering the latest scenarios of the country's economy, Nabil Bank has played a supportive role in modernising Nepal's banking sector, providing dynamism to the country's commercial and industrial activities, and creating employment opportunities in the country. He said that the bank has given top priority to corporate governance and customer satisfaction.

Meanwhile, the bank has been running the Nabil School of Social Entrepreneurship Programme for the development of entrepreneurship in various sectors.

This programme was started to solve long-term social problems through entrepreneurship in society and promote economic and social transformation by promoting enterprises based on innovative thinking, read the statement.

According to it, 335 students have participated in this programme so far, 52 enterprises have been created, and 872 people have been employed. Paudyal informed that the bank is expanding its business by focusing on the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) while also advancing corporate social responsibility programmes based on various goals such as poverty alleviation, education and health.

Nabil has been providing services through its 22 extension counters and 313 ATMs within a network of 266 branches across the country.

GOLD PRICE INCREASES TO RS. 122, 000 PER TOLA

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

The price of gold hit an all-time high in the country on Thursday. According to the Federation of Nepal Gold and Silver Dealers' Association, gold was traded at Rs. 122,000 per tola in the domestic bullion market on Thursday.

It is the highest price of gold ever recorded in Nepal. Earlier on December 4, 2023, the price of gold reached Rs. 121,600 per tola. The rise in its price in the international market is attributed to the surge in gold price in Nepal.

The price of printed gold rose by Rs. 1,300 per tola on Thursday as compared to its price on Wednesday when a tola of gold was traded at Rs. 120,700 in the Nepali market.

Similarly, the price of silver also increased by Rs. 15 per tola and reached Rs. 1,490. Gold trader and former president of FENEGOSIDA Tej Ratna Shakya said that increasing buying pressure of gold in the international market led to the price rise. He said that international investors have been attracted to invest in gold after the Federal Reserve Bank of the United States adopted a policy to reduce the interest rate from the beginning of the New Year 2024.

Krishi Samagri Company Limited
Head Office, Kathmandu Nepal

Approval of Technical Bids and Opening of Price Bids

(Publication Date: December 29, 2023)

This is to inform all concerned that Krishi Samagri Company Limited has decided to open the Price bids of the following bidder for the execution of the Supply and Delivery of Chemical Fertilizer (MOP 0-0-60) - 10,000±2% MT, IFB No: KSCL/P/ICB-159/080/081 published on November 12, 2023 in "The Rising Nepal" and www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp as their bids are found substantially responsive in accordance with the Instructions to Bidders. Successful bidders are invited for their or authorized representative's presence in the following date, time and place:

Name of the bidder	Address
Indian Potash Limited	New Delhi, India

Price bids opening date, time and place:
Date: January 16, 2024
Time: 14:00 hours (Nepal Standard Time)
Place: Krishi Samagri Company Limited, Head Office, Kathmandu Nepal

Foreign tourists surge at Kalinchowk



PHOTO: TRN

Kalinchok Bhagawati, a religious and touristic site, has recently seen a surge in the number of foreign tourists as seen in the picture.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Charikot, Dec. 28

Kalinchok Bhagawati, a religious and touristic site, has recently seen a surge in the number of international tourists.

Ayush Tamang, a member of the Kalinchok Bhagawati Temple Conservation and Management Committee, said that in the past years only domestic tourists flocked to the temple, but as this New Year approaches, there has been an increase in the number of both domestic and foreign tourists in the area.

Hari Oli, a local hotelier, said that around 60 hotels in Kalinchok's market area are booked for the upcoming New Year. According to him, about 70 per cent of the hotel bookings were made by Indian tourists. Local hoteliers say that most Indian tourists booked their hotels for two days while Nepalese tourists booked only for one day.

Oli informed that the Kalinchok Temple, which receives 600 religious tourists at weekends, public holidays and various festivals, is expecting around 100 Indian tourists to come and visit during this new year.

"In the past, there were only a few tourists from other countries, but recently the number of international tourists has increased significantly. The number of tourists visiting Kalinchok Temple is increasing because of its natural beauty and religious importance. These features were publicized abroad through social media in recent times," said Oli.

Tourists from Kerala, West Bengal, Pakistan and Bangladesh have been coming to Kalinchok. Currently, there is an operational cable car and good road connectivity to Dolakha via Ramechhap. Locals say that Kalinchok, located in a small hillock at an altitude of 3,842 metres, receives snowfall every year from March to February, so all kinds of tourists visit Kalinchok, either for religious purpose or to experience the natural beauty.

There is a small pond inside the premises of Kalinchok Bhagawati temple located in Sano Takura. The water level remains the same all year around; according to a legend, it is believed that the water from the pond flowed to Tamakoshi River from a copper stream on the right side and to the Sunkoshi River from a golden stream on the left side.

It is also believed that Parvati, daughter of the Himalaya, performed penance in the Kalinchok Temple premises which later became the abode of Mahadev and Parvati. There are flocks of sheep in the Kalinchok area and a legend says that a pond appeared in the area after a few sheep licked the stones around the Kalinchok Temple.

Invitation for Bids
Government of Nepal
Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport
Department of Roads, Babarmahal, Kathmandu
Date of publication: December 29,2023

1. The Department of Roads, Mechanical Branch invites electronic bids from eligible bidders for the procurement of ***following items*** under National competitive bidding – Single Stage Single Envelope procedures specified in public procurement act and regulations.

S.N	IFB Number	Descriptions	Quantity	Bid Validity	Bid Document fee	Minimum Bid security amount
1	DORMEB/337310113/ 080-81/02	Supply and delivery of Mobile Mini Hot Pre-Mix Mixer	3 Units	90 Days	NRs. 3,000	**NRs. 3,75,000.00**

2. Eligible Bidders may obtain further information and inspect the bidding documents at the office of Department of Roads Mechanical Branch, Babarmahal, Kathmandu or may visit PPMO e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp.
3. Electronic Bidding document is available online and can be downloaded on or before **12:00 Noon, January 28, 2024** for e-submission from PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp. Bidders have to download the necessary part of bidding documents, prepare and submit their bids as specified in Instruction to Bidders. The bidder shall be required to deposit the non-refundable as mentioned above in the Revenue (Rajaswa) account as specified below and electronic scanned copy (pdf format) of Bank Deposit voucher (IFB No. should be clearly mentioned) shall also be submitted along with the electronic bid files.
Information to deposit the cost of bidding document in Bank:
Name of the Bank: Rastriya Banijya Bank, Teku, Kathmandu,Nepal,
Name of Office: Department of Roads, Mechanical Branch — Office Code no.: 337013520
Office Account no.: 1000100200010000 — Rajaswa (revenue) Shirshak no. :14229
4. Electronic bids must be submitted through PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp on or before **12:00 Noon, January 28, 2024.** Bids received after this deadline will be rejected.
5. The bids will be opened in the presence of Bidders' representatives who choose to attend at **1:00 PM** on **January 28, 2024** at the Department of Roads, Mechanical Branch, Babarmahal, Kathmandu. Bids must be valid for a period as mentioned above from the date of bid opening and must be accompanied by a bid security or scanned copy of the bid security in pdf format amounting as mentioned above, which shall be valid for **30 days** beyond the validity period of the bid.

Illegally operating crusher industries put 400 houses at risk in Surkeht

BY RAJANI YOGI
Surkhet, Dec. 28



PHOTO: RAJANI YOGI

A crusher industry operating illegally in Surkhet.

Crusher industries in Surkhet have been in operation without permission despite repeated requests from the municipalities to shut them down.

Barahatal Rural Municipality in Surkhet informed that four crusher industries were operating illegally between Thapadera to Dokpa. They include Himal Sand Processing Industry, Deutimata Sand Processing Industry, Ramjanaki Sand Processing Industry and Kesi Sand Processing Industry.

Bhim Bahadur Bhandari, chairman of the Barahatal Rural Municipality, said that the illegally operating industries posed a risk to settlements along the banks of the Bheri River with around 400 houses in the areas like Thapadera, Pagma, Ranighat and Dopka.

Despite multiple inspections by the officials of the District Administration and District Coordination Committee, the rural municipality stated that no legal action had been taken against the illegal crusher industries. Chairman Bhandari said that the rural municipality could not remove crusher industries on its own due to a lack of human resources although it had the authority to do so.

He said that though excavation of river goods had been prohibited, and the industries were allowed to carry only the excavated construction materials, the industries were resorting to illegal extractions at night.

Similarly, three crusher industries are operating illegally in Lekbeshi Municipality Ward No. 1, 8 and 9 in eastern Surkhet. Mayor Umesh Kumar Paudel said such industries continued to operate openly due to the lack of authorities taking action.

Bheri Sand Processing Industry is being operated in Ward No.1, Pancha Koshi Sand Processing Industry in Ward No. 8 and Dueti Sand Processing Industry in Ward No. 9. Mayor Paudel said that although the administration had been informed about this several times, no legal action had been taken except for inspections.

Gangaram Sunar, chief of Surkhet District Coordination Committee, said that although they had instructed crusher industries to shut down, they had been operating ignoring the notice. He said that 11 crusher industries were currently operating without permission in Surkhet. Since the committee did not have right to take action it had only been instructing the industries.

Meanwhile, District Administration Office Surkhet informed that it would monitor industries based on river products including their extraction, collection and sale-distribution, and would take action if any activities were found happening against the established standards.

NEWS BRIEF

Two kidnapped Nepalis rescued

Gaur: Nepal Police rescued two Nepalis who were abducted from Rautahat and taken to India.

The rescued citizens were identified as Krishna Thapa, 40, of Bharatpur Metrpolis-19, Chitwan, and Dipendra Mahat, 35, of Ratnanagar Muncipality-12, Chitwan.

The District Police Office, Rautahat, said that they were rescued from Sitamadhi of India. Rautahat Police had reached India to make an effort for their release. They were abducted when they reached Rautahat from Chitwan on December 21, SP Mahendra Kumar Shrestha said.

On December 23, Krishna Thapa, one of the victims, telephoned his wife and informed her about their abduction and asked for a ransom amount of Rs. 600,000. Following their release, they were handed over to their families.

Indian Police have also arrested six Indian abductors identified as Mohammad Akbar, Mohammad Naim, Kaushar Ali, Mohammad Sadab, Mohammad Irsad and Ram Naresh Kumar of Sitamadhi, India.

Two held for extortion

Sarlahi: Police have arrested two persons allegedly involved in extorting locals and businessmen in the Harion market of Sarlahi district.

The Area Police Office, Harion, said that the arrested included Chetnath Adhikari, 45, of Hariharpurgadhi Rural Municipality-7 of Sindhuli and Raju Hada, 50, Chandrapur Municipality-1, Rautahat.

Police Inspector Anil Raj Giri said that they were arrested after the police administration received complaints against them. The police got a three-day remand order to investigate them from the District Court on Thursday, said police.

(TRN)

Local levels should deal with people's problems: Gurung



PHOTO: RADHA KRISHNA DUMRE

Minister for Federal Affairs, Justice and Law Dhan Raj Gurung speaking at a health camp in Chapakot, Syangja on Thursday.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Dec. 28

Dhanraj Gurung, Minister for Federal Affairs, Justice and Law, has said that the local government should directly deal with the problems of the citizens.

"After we adopted the federal system, the local levels have received many rights and responsibilities, and they should be continuously connected with the citizens," said Minister Gurung while addressing a programme organised in Chapakot Municipality on Thursday.

"The current government is committed to fulfilling the basic needs of the citizens including education and health," said Minister Gurung.

Chapakot Municipality has started a campaign to provide health services to its citizens by reaching the village areas. Deb Bahadur Khand (Ishwor), Mayor of Chapakot Municipality, informed that the purpose of running a large-scale free health camp was to solve the health-related problems of the citizens of the village area.

Mayor Ishwor informed that a team of health workers were deployed in the village area to make the service easily accessible to the citizens. "An agreement has been signed with the healthcare workers to conduct health camps in all wards of Chapakot Municipality," he added.

Dhruv Khanal, Chief District Officer of Syangja district, said that free health check-ups, video X-rays, ECG, eye tests, dental tests, facilitation for family planning and blood and urine tests were provided at the camp.

Lack of regulation hinders utilisation of forest resources

BY SASHIDHAR PARAJULI
Biratnagar, Dec. 28

While the provincial government holds the authority to develop and manage the forest area, the utilisation of forest resources and the progress of forest development work have been obstructed by a lack of timely regulation.

Despite the enactment of the Province Forest Act 2076 (2019) by the Koshi Province government to advance forest sector development, crucial regulations are yet to be established.

The lack of a regulatory framework hampers progress in forest protection, resource consumption, public property rights, development delays, tourism, and wildlife conservation.

The government is also struggling to address issues such as illegal activities due to a lack of regulation and the failure to implement existing one.

When timely and planned efforts are not made to address the issues, the Koshi Province government's work is limited to the security and development of the forest sector. It is also losing millions of revenues every year.

Until the end of three years after the enactment of the Province Forest Act, rules, procedures, and standards have not been formulated. The law passed by the parliament has not been implemented. The absence of regulations hinders the collection and sale of river-based materials and gravel from within the forest area, impacting potential earnings. This has also limited the internal revenue of local bodies and the provincial government.

The absence of such regulations, procedures, and standards has prevented the sustainable harvesting of timber from the forest area. This has led to insufficient availability of wood for local consumers, forcing them to import timber from foreign sources.

The Secretary of the Ministry of Tourism, Forests, and Environment, Bishal Ghimire, has stressed the urgent need to pass and implement forest regulations to mitigate encroachment and damage caused by unsustainable mining and construction activities in the forest area.

Ghimire said that the Ministry is working earnestly to pass the legislation, streamline necessary procedures, and establish standards to facilitate its implementation. He added, "I have recently assumed office at the Ministry, and although I am in the early stages of my tenure, we are advancing the work to pass the regulations within a week."

Due to the absence of regulations, the government has not been able to transfer the income from the tourist sites established in the community forest areas to the provincial accumulated fund. The Act demands that 5 per cent of the income from such tourism activities should be deposited in the Provincial Accumulated Fund.

Community and leasehold forests registered between 2003 to 2008 face challenges in enrolling with the Internal Revenue Office. Despite government mandates for registration, forests in low-income hilly areas struggle to pay taxes from the registration date. The Divisional Forest Office in Khotang stressed the need for revenue to be charged only from the mandatory PAN registration date. It has said that without PAN registration, they are unable to implement forest protection and development programmes in the area.

The discontinuation of timber harvesting as per forest management and regular operational plans has led to an imbalance in wood supply to the market. So, consumers in the southern regions are unable to obtain timber easily.

The scientific forest management programme being hindered has impacted timber production. The government's preparations to advance it through the Forest Prosperity Programme are also perceived as slow. The sluggish implementation of the Forest Act has resulted in financial aberrations among forest users' groups. There is a disagreement between the province and local authorities over land rights for development projects. Forest employees suggest having a mandatory system to settle disputes before starting any development work either by the province or local authorities.

Currently, Ministry of Tourism, Forests, and Environment is facing a 45 per cent shortage of staff. Secretary Ghimire, said that the timely recruitment of employees by the Provincial Public Service Commission is crucial. The shortage is obstructing the implementation of programmes related to forest security, development, conservation, and management at the grassroots level, he added.

FUTURE WATCH

What you have in store for 2024

Based on birth names

D. N. Lohani

ARIES
A good year is in your store. Major tasks will be completed. Confusion will prevail till February. Financial status will improve. You may have to handle a new venture which will yield a good return. Employees will observe a better period.

TAURUS
Expenditure level will rise till April and come under control thereafter. Doubts and confusion can prevail within the self. Don't anticipate notable breakthroughs but smaller tasks will complete successfully. The year looks better considering your love life.

GEMINI
Expenditure will exceed your expectations, especially after April. You will enjoy notable gains in March and April. Love-related development will take a longer time to materialise. Foreign travel can occur. Your study will take the progressive course.

CANCER
Study-related obstacles will be removed after three months. You will retain a progressive trend. Employees won't experience much progress. The business will yield an ordinary return. Anxiety can arise during March.

LEO
Opponents will remain active. Love-life will take a progressive course starting in May. Friends will provide appreciable support. Students will experience an ordinary period, but the results may be less satisfying.

VIRGO
Avoid risky ventures in April. Circumstances will improve from mid-May. You will boldly face opponents. You will have a prosperous travel in the second half of the year. New friends will join your circle. The investment will generate a good return.

LIBRA
Controversial issues can lead to expenses. Litigation matters can waste time and money. Employees may not experience major progress. Students will have to work harder. You will retain impressive progress in June and July.

SCORPIO
Prevailing problems will disappear from May. Your study will take a progressive course. Employees will observe lower progress. Health condition will remain ordinary. You may face pain in the leg or portion lower than hip. Business will continue as usual.

SAGITTARIUS
Students will have to work harder. The first four months are progressive. Employees may experience growth. Trade and profession both will turn profitable. Love-life can suffer a setback after May.

CAPRICORN
Despite hardship, the job will provide lower satisfaction. Travel is in store for you. The second half of the year is better for employees. The intellectual assignment will yield a return. You will find it difficult to control your expenditure. The study will take a progressive course.

AQUARIUS
Ordinary year is in store for you. You will retain partial progress in obligation. Health disorder is predicted. Love-life can face obstacles. Travel-related expenses can rise.

PISCES
Work will be completed successfully after causing extra expenses. You may have to handle profitable new obligations. Trade and profession both will turn profitable. A high level of confidence will guide you ahead after mid-May. Family problems will continue.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Truth will ultimately prevail where there is pains to bring it to light.
- George Washington

EDITORIAL

Gains In Health Sector

With the implementation of the government's strategic action plans, Nepal's heath sector has witnessed remarkable progress in the last one year. The Ministry of Health and Population's (MoHP) has put its best foot forward to address the issues such as sexual violence, mental health, and financial allocation. Ensuring everyone's access to quality health services is crucial for public well-being. The country's healthcare policy must be tailored to this direction. Relentless efforts, taken by Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda-led government, have yielded positive outcomes. Still there is room for the improvement for the effective execution of policies. At the same time, it is also necessary to take the stock of the programmes and schemes that seek to increase the access of poor and marginalised to the health facilities. Transparency and constant monitoring help overcome inherent shortcomings while enhancing the capacity of service delivery.

One important decision is that health workers are obliged to return to their designated workplaces, particularly in rural areas. When the workforce is evenly distributed, the equitable access to health utilities becomes possible. Approximately 800 health workers have been identified working outside their designated areas, prompting the government to call for their return, a move that aligns with global recommendations for optimal healthcare delivery. Telemedicine services, a modern solution to bridge urban-rural healthcare disparities, have been introduced. The initiative allows senior doctors in urban areas to consult with patients and doctors in rural regions through internet and telephone services. The success of telemedicine hinges on its widespread accessibility, especially in remote areas where healthcare resources are scarce.

According to the report of the World Health Organisation, there is a need of nearly 92,100 healthcare workers across the nation. Currently, with around 30,000 healthcare professionals, the government's call for collaboration between local, provincial, and central authorities to meet this deficit is encouraging. However, swift and effective implementation of plans to add another 30,000 health workers is expected to address the increasing demands on the healthcare system. The collaboration between the MoHP, Education Ministry, and Nepal Medical Education Commission to amend the medical education act is a positive step. This aims to provide opportunities for aspiring medical professionals to study within the country contributing to the long-term sustainability of the healthcare workforce.

Many a challenge still persists. The construction of basic hospitals demands stringent oversight for smooth operation. Reliance on leased buildings raises concerns about the sustainability and quality of healthcare services delivered. The government's commitment to providing free medical services for economically disadvantaged citizens and the elderly is praiseworthy. However, monitoring the allocation of 10 per cent of beds in private hospitals for these groups is essential to ensure equitable access. The introduction health insurance system, while strategic, requires careful implementation to genuinely support economically disadvantaged citizens.

As we move to envision a healthier future, it's important to focus on long-term solutions and adjust our strategies based on what the people need. The government needs to make sure that the plans they make turn into real improvements so that everyone in the country can benefit. The government should also be bold to sort out the bigger problems like irregularities and anomalies that erode efficiency and deprive the people of health service. Similarly, the government should focus on ensuring adequate infrastructure, medical equipment, human resources and medicines.

Social Media's Uncanny Focus

BINI DAHAL

My Christmas afternoon was peaceful until social media began rattling. Apparently, popular Bollywood actor parents had 'unveiled' their daughter to the public. And everyone was gushing over how the kid had the eyes of her great-grandfather, a legendary actor of India, among other observations. Now why am I even talking about this? It is partly because the popularity of Indian films and TV serials have spread well to Nepal. So, owing to the proximity and the popularity, we are not completely unaware of what is going on there. I had a kind headache after I felt I was being over-fed with this news.

My overly critical and rational mind felt that having uncanny resemblance to family members is a normal thing as genetic traits are transferred from generation to generation, which is clearly highlighted by popular scientists like Gregor Mendel. When I shared this with one of my friends, she cut me off by saying I was over-exaggerating and that discussions as such even took place when there is a new-born in a normal family. And I had to agree with her silently.

But I still wanted to make a point. The comments are filled with how cute and lovely the child looked. I counter this by saying it is normal for kids that age to be adorable. My other friend gives her input saying how the kid's fair skin and blue eyes must have been a reason for the media frenzy. And as I write this, I still am confused and find it hilarious that a one-year-old kid is already so popular.

The parents of the said child had requested the media to not take pictures of their little one, and for the last one year, the public was unaware as to how the child looked. And now, the parents themselves have come up and showed their kid's face. The matter of discussion here is not whether a celebrity should make their children a topic of discussion in social media and public platforms. But it's more about the kind of response and news highlight that comes with such a public showcase. We are fed with this news because we are more than interested to probe into the lives of the well-known.

While I read all of the headlines and was bombarded with the photo of the kid everywhere, I couldn't help but feel that maybe, we have much more important things going on in the world. The kid is gifted with great genes for sure and will continue to live a life full of privileges. But let's face it. There are children who are suffering from poverty, hunger and malnutrition. Ongoing wars in different parts of the globe have taken their lives and the lives of their dear ones, making them orphan and helpless.

Has anyone realised how it should have been colder but the days are scorching hot? We seem to have failed to prioritise matters and the media knows it very well that only the entertaining news sells and gets a lot of attention. The constant gossip and news seems to be a good validation and a break from the constant stress and monotonous life. As I try making a point, someone else might be preparing to drop another entertaining breaking news. I am sure this will continue in the future, too. So, while I rant, I might as well prepare myself for creative future headlines and news articles.

Lesson From Gulf Nations' Rise



Dr. Narad Bharadwaj

The development momentum, achieved by the Gulf countries during the past few decades, has astonished the world, providing valuable lessons for other smaller countries which are struggling to lead their people to prosperity. Among the Gulf countries, Saudi Arabia, United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Qatar have achieved a miraculous transformation, lifting their people from dirt poverty 50 years ago to the frontline of prosperous nations. As these countries edge closer to geopolitical central stage on the strength of their economic prowess, they are also offering a huge job markets for unemployed youths from many countries of South Asia and South East Asia where the rate of unemployment is high.

Nepal alone has over 1.2 million youths working in various Gulf countries. But little do these countries appear to realise that they could gain more insight from their success stories than from their employment markets. One of the smallest countries Qatar, with tiny geography confined within 11,571 sq. km, has set an example on how a small country surrounded by hostile circumstances and limited resources can become prosperous and developed in a short span of time, achieving one of the highest GDP rankings in the world.

Qatar's miraculous success

Qatar's journey from an economically challenged country sustained by limited conventional resources like trade in pearls and marine foods extracted from the sea with the help of professional divers and limited trade with Saudi Arabia through surface road to a modern educated and prosperous country is unbelievable. Its ability to successfully organise FIFA World Cup Games-2022 gathering cumulative 3.4 million people in Doha has held the world in thrall.

There is no doubt that almost all the Gulf countries have been endowed with massive reserves of oil and gas resources. But history shows that existence of resources alone is not sufficient to make countries prosperous and modernised. A careful study of the development paradigm followed by Arab countries shows that a visionary and determined leadership, farsighted strategic planning and prudential investment in sustainable future is critical for attaining development goals. Their success lies in their ability to look beyond fossil fuel and invest in areas like tourism, sports, finance, health, education and technology, creating multiple streams of revenues.

Qatar's successful organisation of FIFA World Games -2022 was one of the major policy initiatives taken to diversify the sources of economy. Qatar, UAE and Saudi Arabia are now using the economic boom achieved through the sale of oil and gas resources as leverage for attaining goals of Vision-2030.They have a strategic goal of making their countries highly developed capable of ensuring decent standard of living for their people by 2030. As the Gulf region comes under intense impact of extreme weather conditions brought about rapid climate change, they are feeling the urgency of building resilient economy to cope with the unexpected climate emergencies.

In the face of surging heat index, rising sea level and the looming specter of having to shift from petroleum based to renewable energy resources in the near future, the Arab nations are already re-drafting their economic roadmap for the future. In response to the call for achieving the goals for Vision-2030, the largest and the richest country of the Gulf region Saudi Arabia has embarked on accomplishing a mega city project worth $500 billion to be built along the

> Their success lies in their ability to look beyond fossil fuel and invest in areas like tourism, sports, finance, health, education and technology, creating multiple streams of revenues.

shore of the Red Sea. The dream city extending over 450 km will be totally run through renewable energy providing housing for 9 million people. Upon completion, this city is said to earn yearly revenue of $100 billion, contributing to $ 48 billion to GDP by 2030.

United Arab Emirates (UAE), too, is going all out to create economic resilience to sustain the shock of post petroleum era by building futuristic infrastructures in the field of commerce, tourism, sports, sustainable agriculture and other sectors with a view to provide a secured living for the people. It is making unbelievable investment in the field of air transport, railway networks, world class hotels and high-tech malls. Burj Khalifa, the tallest building in the world, Dubai Mall, one of the largest in the world and Palm Jumeirah, Earth Island are some of the iconic projects which the Emirate has invested on to ensure that revenue streams based on green resources will continue to sustain its economy even after weaning away from fossil fuel.

As a major strategy for diversified investment and laying emphasis on creating multiple revenue streams, almost all the Gulf countries are also investing sizeable amount of their revenue on sustainable food security through promoting cutting-edge technology to support agricultural projects. In 2020, the UAE decided to form a task force for developing modern agriculture to achieve self-sufficiency in foods. It is, now, investing a huge amount of resource in agricultural research in addition to supporting FAO's efforts towards sustainable foods security in the world. According to a news report published on September 11, 2020, UAE has a plan to achieve 30 per cent self-sufficiency in foods by 2025.

Circuitous path

Saudi Arabia is also making serious efforts to reduce reliance on food import and create buffer against disruption in international supply chain. It has already achieved near self- sufficiency in poultry (70 per cent) meat (57per cent), fish (60 per cent). In dairy products Saudi Arabia and Qatar have already achieved self-sufficiency and are selling their surplus products to international markets. According to an Arab News article http://arab.news/c9jxm), Saudi Arabia has achieved 63 per cent self-sufficiency in value added agriculture sector.

The Gulf countries have travelled circuitous path to reach where they are today but the experience they have gained constitute rich knowledge resources for the countries negotiating their path to prosperity through the quagmire of problems. The lessons of their success stories could be that if a country's leadership is visionary to identify sustainable resources and harness them prudentially, diversify revenue streams, make strategic planning aligning them with long-term goal and invest in future anticipating unforeseen geo-political, climatic and demographic challenges, a nation can successfully carve its path to development and prosperity.

(Dr. Bharadwaj is former ambassador and former chairperson of Gorkhapatra Corporation. bharadwajnarad@gmail.com.)

Media Must Be Highly Responsible



Lok Deep Thapa

There is no doubt that the political parties and their leaders have been guiding the nation for many years now. As per the democratic norms, people now are enjoying not only freedom of speech and expression, but also the ability to enjoy an independent life. Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda-led government has just completed one year in office and though there have been criticism from many sectors and individuals about the government, ordinary onlookers like this writer feel that the Prime Minister and his cabinet partners have been involved in many works, both politically and diplomatically. It may have been a little more slack in development works and in the improvement of the economy, but every day one hears about the activities of the government for constructive actions.

Prime Minister Prachanda admitted in his address to the nation that he himself was not satisfied with the slow progress in some sectors and he would personally monitor the initiatives taken by different ministries. But right in the beginning he also talked of the achievements made by the government in many sectors. He claimed that his party and the government were working for the protection of Loktantra and other democratic ideals in spite of the attacks in the basic base of the achievements by some forces who were deliberately trying to incite more trouble in the nation.

Stride in power generation

One achievement was that the country had taken a huge stride in generating electricity. This is true as now most parts of the country not only has access to electricity, but there is no load-shedding, especially in capital city - Kathmandu, and the country has been even exporting power worth billions of rupees. This is a far cry from the days when the whole country suffered from massive load-shedding, even up to eighteen hours per day. Now the people are getting used to using more electric gadgets for daily works including in cooking. Many experts have been saying that Nepal would benefit immensely if it used electricity instead of fossil fuels which it has to import at a high cost.

The Prime Minister also boldly stated in his address that he was ready to step down if the people thought his government was inefficient. But he also reminded all that he would change his working style in his second year in office and sternly deal with individuals, including ministers and diplomats who were proved inefficient in their work. There is no doubt that what the people are expecting is good governance and it was encouraging to learn that Prachanda was very serious on this matter. All will have to contribute in their own ways to help such determination of the head of the government.

However, it was dismaying to see much criticism of the government in many media outlets. The media has an important role to play in pointing the focus of the people in the right direction. Not only because this writer worked there, but he is saying this as it is the truth, that The Rising Nepal has not only been encouraging developmental

> There is no doubt that what the people are expecting is good governance and it was encouraging to learn that Prachanda was very serious on this matter.

journalism, but it has also always been accountable and responsible. There was a time when even scholars read this daily just to see correct English language and there were many others who read it for its reliability and also wide coverage of international news and also sports.

The other media outlets sadly seem to be not only partisan but also very biased in their news and views. Forget being ethical, they are not even following the written code of conduct of journalism. Like with the political leaders, the people seem to be having lesser and lesser faith in what the media says these days. This is not a good indicator for the media as a whole. But to come back to the situation of the country, it is encouraging to hear the commitment of none less than the Prime Minister himself that he is very serious about good governance and the development works in all sectors. He also emphatically said that his government would take serious note of the plight of the people and make all efforts to mitigate the problems faced by the common citizens. It is the duty of all to cooperate with the government, especially the political leaders and bureaucrats, to make this vision a success.

Positive sign

The media also has an important role in helping make a better Nepal. Here, one must commend the work of TRN in being the leader in giving positive news and making developmental news a trend which encourages individuals to contribute for the betterment of the nation's economy, not by going abroad, but by staying back in the country and using their energy and skills here. It is indeed a positive sign that other media outlets are also now following this trend and giving good coverage of the success stories of individuals who are using the opportunities found here in the country itself.

Just criticising the government, political leaders or others is not a difficult job, but at the same time the responsible individuals in high public posts must also be careful that they do not get involved in any controversies which attract the wrath of the common people or the media. The media should also be careful that they not make a mountain out of a mole hill, unless they have enough proof so that they can responsibly again inform the people of how the report they have published has come up with results and what follow-up had taken place. Objectivity is perhaps the most difficult part of journalism, but as it has a huge responsibility, the media outlets, whether in the print sector or the broadcast sector must be careful that wrong information or opinion are not given because of their inclination to support one group or the other.

(The author is former chief editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 29, 1973

235 Cases Disposed In Myagdi

Beni, Dec 28: Myagdi district court disposed of 235 cases in the last fiscal year.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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READER'S MAIL

Kiwi Cultivation Getting Viable

This is in reference to a news report titled "*Farmers in Taplejung become happy after kiwi fruit gets good market*" published in your prestigious daily on Thursday.

According to the news report, the export of kiwi fruits to Jhapa, Kathmandu and other locations around Nepal has made the farmers in Taplejung very happy. Apparently, Tiringe, a location in the district, has been supplying more than 15 quintals of kiwi produced outside the district. This comes after the village of Tiringe was announced as a pocket district for kiwi production. The rural municipality has been providing subsidies to the farmers involved in the production of the fruit.

This is a good development indicating how agricultural produce grown within the country has the potential to take up the market. By promoting the local produce and making sure it reaches every nook and corner of the



country will surely help the economy and the livelihood of the people.

The government should continue encouraging the farmers with incentives and technical assistance just so that Nepal's agriculture sector flourishes. Also, necessary promotion should be done to make people aware of the produce growing in the country. Strategic plans should be adopted.

Anusha Pokharel
Sanothimi, Bhaktapur

TAILPIECE

A man in Amsterdam felt that he needed to confess, so he went to his priest.

"Forgive me, Father, for I have sinned," he said. "During World War II, I hid a refugee in my attic."

"Well," said the priest. "That's not a sin."

"But I made him agree to pay me $20 for every week he stayed," the man explained.

"I admit that wasn't good, but you did it for a good cause," the priest replied.

"Oh, thank you, Father. That eases my mind," the man said. "I have one more question, though."

"What is that, my son?" the priest inquired.

"Do I have to tell him the war is over?"

Sudan civilians rush for arms

AFP
Sudan, Dec. 28



The paramilitary Rapid Support Forces (RSF) have seized most of Sudan's southern Al-Jazira state including its capital Wad Madani and begun pushing further south into Sennar state in their war against the army.

Amid growing claims of abuses by RSF fighters, groups of civilians have called for "armed popular resistance" across the Sudanese states of White Nile, River Nile, Gedaref, North, Kassala and Red Sea.

The RSF meanwhile has ordered inhabitants of areas brought under its control to provide the paramilitary force with volunteers who would be armed to "protect their territory".

The fighting since April 15 pits army chief Abdel Fattah al-Burhan against his former deputy, RSF commander Mohamed Hamdan Daglo.

The violence has killed more than 12,000 people, according to a conservative estimate by the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project.

The UN says at least 7.1 million people have been displaced, including 1.5 million who fled across the border into neighbouring countries.

Last week at a thousands-strong rally in the northern city of Shendi, River Nile state governor Mohammed Badawi said: "We are going to train young people on weapons, so that they can defend their lands and their honour, and protect the families from the rebellion" of the RSF.

In the coastal city of Suakin, south of Port Sudan, a Beja tribal leader, Mohammed al-Amin Turk, announced on Monday: "We are ready to take up arms (against the RSF) for the victory."

In a village in Al-Jazira state's west, one resident -- requesting anonymity for safety concerns -- told AFP that the paramilitaries have already handed out weapons.

"The RSF are arming a number of young men in each village, giving them Kalashnikovs and one or more cars, depending on the size of the village," he said.

The proliferation of arms has spurred fears that the conflict might spill over beyond the ranks of the army and the RSF.

According to the Small Arms Survey project, 6.6 percent of Sudan's 48 million people have weapons.

The risks are particularly grave in the vast western region of Darfur, already scarred by bloody violence in the 2000s that killed about 300,000 people.

Darfur as well as Kordofan in the south and the capital Khartoum have borne much of the brunt of the current war.

The United Nations in May warned that armed civilians, tribal fighters and rebel groups had already taken up arms in Darfur.

The calls now to arm more civilians "are disastrous", a Sudanese security official told AFP, requesting anonymity.

"They add fuel to the fire, in a country already suffering from the proliferation of weapons."

To Sherif Mohammed Othman, a leader of Sudan's main civilian alliance the Forces for Freedom and Change, "we must call on both parties to put an end to the conflict, instead of encouraging citizens to join the popular resistance or the ranks of the army."

"The only thing it would do is prolong the war," he said.

A government agency tasked with collecting arms estimated that at the end of 2022, "five million weapons were in the hands of civilians, excluding those of rebel groups in Darfur, South Kordofan and Blue Nile" states.

The security official said that it was likely an underestimate.

"Even before the war, gun permits had become easy to obtain" and many weapons were being smuggled into Sudan from neighbouring countries, the official said.

Al-Jazira state resident Yussef Ali said he was determined to be armed.

"If no side gives me a weapon, I'll buy one myself," he said.

US announces new weapons package for Ukraine

AP
Washington, Dec. 28

The U.S. on Wednesday announced what officials say could be the final package of military aid to Ukraine unless Congress approves supplemental funding legislation that is stalled on Capitol Hill.

The weapons, worth up to $250 million, include an array of air munitions and other missiles, artillery, anti-armor systems, ammunition, demolition and medical equipment and parts. The aid, provided through the Presidential Drawdown Authority, will be pulled from Pentagon stockpiles.

In a statement, Marine Lt. Col. Garron Garn, a Pentagon spokesman said there is no more funding to replace the weapons taken from department stocks. And the Ukraine Security Assistance Initiative, which provides long-term funding for future weapons contracts, is also out of money.

As a result, Garn said Wednesday, "Without the supplemental funding, there will be a shortfall in replenishing U.S. military stocks, affecting American military readiness."

President Joe Biden is urging Congress to pass a $110 billion aid package for Ukraine, Israel and other national security needs. It includes $61.4 billion for Ukraine, with about half to replenish Pentagon stocks. It also includes about $14 billion for Israel as it fights Hamas and $14 billion for U.S. border security. Other funds would go for security needs in the Asia-Pacific.

Due to an accounting error that overvalued some of the weapons sent to Ukraine over the past year or more, there is still about $4.2 billion in restored drawdown authority. But since the Pentagon has no money to replenish inventory sent to Kyiv, the department will have to "rigorously assess" any future aid and its implications on the U.S. military's ability to protect America, Garn said.

This is the 54th tranche of military aid taken from department shelves and sent to Ukraine, and it is similar in size and contents to many of the other recent packages.

U.S. defense and government leaders have argued that the weapons are critical for Ukraine to maintain its defense and continue efforts to mount an offensive against Russian forces during the winter months.

In a Pentagon briefing last week, Air Force Maj. Gen. Pat Ryder noted the recent letter that the Defense Department comptroller sent to Congress warning that the U.S. will be using up the last of its replenishment funds by the end of the year.

Israel bombs Gaza as UN warns 'grave peril'

AFP
Gaza Strip, Dec. 28



PHOTO: AFP
Israeli soldiers patrol along the Israel-Gaza border

Israeli forces on Thursday heavily bombed besieged Gaza as the centre of fierce combat against Hamas moves steadily south, where hundreds of thousands of displaced Palestinians are sheltering.

The war that started with the Hamas attack of October 7 has devastated much of northern Gaza, while air and artillery strikes and house-to-house fighting have been heaviest in the southern city of Khan Yunis.

The Israeli army has deployed an additional brigade to Khan Yunis, the hometown of Hamas leader Yahya Sinwar, said army spokesman Daniel Hagari.

UN World Health Organisation chief Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus called for "urgent steps to alleviate the grave peril" facing Gaza's people, including "terrible injuries, acute hunger and... severe risk of disease".

French President Emmanuel Macron in a call with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu voiced his "deepest concern at the very heavy civilian toll" and stressed "the need to work towards a lasting ceasefire", Macron's office said.

Israel has vowed to destroy Hamas in retaliation for its bloody October 7 attack, which left about 1,140 people dead, most of them civilians, according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

The Hamas gunmen also took around 250 hostages, 129 of whom remain in captivity -- a source of intense grief and anxiety for their families who have held protests demanding urgent action to "bring them home".

Israel's relentless aerial bombardment and ground invasion with troops and tanks have killed at least 21,110 people, mostly women and children, according to Gaza's Hamas-run health ministry.

The Israeli army says 167 of its soldiers have been killed in the war in Gaza.

Turkish Parliament unlikely to vote on Sweden's NATO bid

AFP
Istanbul, Dec. 28



PHOTO: AFP
The Turkish parliament is on recess until January 15.

Turkey's parliament is unlikely to hold a full vote on Sweden's bid to join NATO before mid-January, parliamentary sources told AFP Thursday.

Sweden's accession to the US-led Western alliance was approved by the foreign affairs committee on Tuesday, bringing an end in sight to a 19-month standoff that drew the wrath of Turkey's Western partners.

It must now be voted by the full 600-seat parliament, where President Recep Tayyip Erdogan's ruling alliance holds the majority. The president would then need to sign it into law.

Although Erdogan's party could call for a special session to discuss the measure, it appears likely it will wait until after parliament's scheduled return on January 15.

The Nordic country, together with its neighbour Finland, abandoned decades of military non-alignment and sought to join NATO after Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022.

Turkey and Hungary were the only NATO members to oppose their applications. Turkey eventually relented on Finland, but continued to accuse Sweden of failing to crack down on exiled Kurdish groups that Ankara views as "terrorists".

Sweden tightened its anti-terrorism legislation in response to Turkish pressure, and Erdogan lifted his objections to Sweden's application at a NATO summit in July, while pushing for concessions from the United States.

Erdogan made Turkey's ratification of Sweden's application conditional on the US Congress "simultaneously" approving Ankara's request for 40 F-16 jets and spare parts.

Even though the US administration has promised to move forward with the sale, its approval has met resistance from Congress.

Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan discussed Sweden's NATO membership in a phone call with US Secretary of State Antony Blinken on Wednesday, a diplomatic source said, a day after the protocol was greenlighted by the parliament committee.

Fidan told Blinken that Turkey now expects the US administration and Congress to "to act in line with the spirit of alliance and to fulfil the commitments made" with regard to the F-16s.

NATO chief Jens Stoltenberg hailed the parliamentary committee's approval of Sweden's NATO bid, urging Turkey and fellow holdout Hungary to complete their ratifications "as soon as possible".

PRISM

Rescuer saves cat with head stuck in jar

New Jersey: A volunteer animal rescuer in New Jersey was able to rescue a cat seen wandering for several days with a jar stuck over its head.

John DeBacker, vice president of Long Island Cat/Kitten Solution, was alerted to the plight of the feline in Irvington by fellow volunteer rescuers Marcia Sandford Fishkind and Eileen DiNicola.

DeBacker said he asked to be notified of any further sightings, and on Christmas Day his phone lit up with alerts that the gray tabby had been spotted.

DeBacker posted a video to Facebook showing how he safely captured the cat and removed the jar from its head.

Unusual talents and skills will be put to test in 2024

New York: Unusual talents and skills will be put to the test in 2024 in categories including wife-carrying, underwater chess, dog ugliness and mullet-sporting.

The coming year will see famous contests including Super Bowl LVIII, the Paris Summer Olympics and even a U.S. presidential election, but what of lesser-known -- but no less important -- events such as the Heavy Metal Knitting World Championships, the World Gravy Wrestling Championships and the Snail Racing World Championships?

In honor of these niche challenges and the competitors who proudly represent their home countries, UPI Odd News is proud to present 10 of the oddest competitions in the world.

The world's most aesthetically challenged canines gather each year at the Sonoma-Marin Fair to see which of them can capture the hearts of judges and the public.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1778 – American Revolutionary War: Three thousand British soldiers under the command of Lieutenant Colonel Archibald Campbell capture Savannah, Georgia.
1835 – The Treaty of New Echota is signed, ceding all the lands of the Cherokee east of the Mississippi River to the United States.
1911 – Mongolia gains independence from the Qing dynasty, enthroning 8th Jebtsundamba Khutughtu as Khagan of Mongolia.
1934 – Japan renounces the Washington Naval Treaty of 1922 and the London Naval Treaty of 1930.
1937 – The Irish Free State is replaced by a new state called Ireland with the adoption of a new constitution.
2003 – The last known speaker of Akkala Sami dies, rendering the language extinct.
2020 – A large explosion at the airport in the southern Yemeni city of Aden kills at least 22 people and wounds 50.

The year of social media soul-searching Threads, X are born and AI gets personal

AP
New York, Dec. 28

We lost Twitter and got X. We tried out Bluesky and Mastodon (well, some of us did). We fretted about AI bots and teen mental health. We cocooned in private chats and scrolled endlessly as we did in years past. For social media users, 2023 was a year of beginnings and endings, with some soul-searching in between.

Here's a look back some of the biggest stories in social media in 2023 — and what to watch for next year:

A little more than a year ago, Elon Musk walked into Twitter 's San Francisco headquarters, fired its CEO and other top executives and began transforming the social media platform into what's now known as X.

Musk revealed the X logo in July. It quickly replaced Twitter's name and its whimsical blue bird icon, online and on the company's San Francisco headquarters.

"And soon we shall bid adieu to the twitter brand and, gradually, all the birds," Musk posted on the site.

Because of its public nature and because it attracted public figures, journalists and other high-profile users, Twitter always had an outsized influence on popular culture — but that influence seems to be waning.

Since Musk's takeover, X has been bombarded by allegations of misinformation and racism, endured significant advertising losses and suffered declines in usage. It didn't help when Musk went on an expletive-ridden rant in an on-stage interview about companies that had halted spending on X. Musk asserted that advertisers that pulled out were engaging in "blackmail" and, using a profanity, essentially told them to get lost.

Continuing the trend of welcoming back users who had been banned by the former Twitter for hate speech or spreading misinformation, in December, Musk restored the X account of conspiracy theorist Alex Jones, pointing to an unscientific poll he posted to his followers that came out in favor of the Infowars host who repeatedly called the 2012 Sandy Hook school shooting a hoax.

LGBTQ and other organizations supporting marginalized groups, meanwhile, have been raising alarms about X becoming less safe. In April, for instance, it quietly removed a policy against the "targeted misgendering or deadnaming of transgender individuals. In June, the advocacy group GLAAD called it "the most dangerous platform for LGBTQ people."

GLSEN, an LGBTQ education group, announced in December that it was leaving X, joining other groups such as the suicide prevention nonprofit Trevor Project, saying that Musk's changes "have birthed a new platform that enables its users to harass and target the LGBTQ+ community without restriction or discipline."



PHOTO: AP
Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg speaks during the tech giant's Connect developer conference on Sept. 27, 2023, in Menlo Park, Calif.

Musk's ambitions for X include transforming the platform into an "everything app" — like China's WeChat, for instance. The problem? It's not clear if U.S. and Western audiences are keen on the idea. And Musk himself has been pretty vague on the specifics.

While X contends with an identity crisis, some users began looking for a replacement. Mastodon was one contender, along with Bluesky, which actually grew out of Twitter — a pet project of former CEO Jack Dorsey, who still sits on its board of directors.

When tens of thousands of people, many of them fed-up Twitter users, began signing up for the (still) invite-only Bluesky in the spring, the app had less than 10 people working on it, said CEO Jay Graber recently.

This meant "scrambling to keep everything working, keeping people online, scrambling to add features that we had on the roadmap," she said. For weeks, the work was simply "scaling" — ensuring that the systems could handle the influx.



PHOTO: BASANTA PARAJULI/TRN

Students participating in 'United Tech Fusion 2080' showing how robot cars are used to play the football competition.

Football match with robots as players

BY BASANTA PARAJULI
Narayangadh, Dec. 28

United Technical College in Ward No. 11 of Bharatpur Metropolitan City organised a football competition of robots in a two-day 'United Tech Fusion 2080' programme. The programme was organised by the United Tech Club in the facilitation of United Technical College.

Eight teams from the technical and engineering colleges of Chitwan, Kathmandu and Pokhara participated in the competition.

According to the organisers, the robotic football competition became the most awaited attraction for visitors.

There were 21 other projects showcased in the Tech Fusion from students of 10 colleges across the country. Capture the Flag (CTF), a kind of computer security competition, was the second most loved attraction.

The teams participating in the football competition had prepared small car-like remote-controlled robots. The robots were then used as players in a small artificial field with smaller balls and goalposts to play football.

Each robot car was equipped with a bulldozer-like blade at the front, serving the purpose of pushing a ball towards the opponent's goalpost. In this one-on-one competition, each team utilised a single robot car, making it the striker, defender, and goalie all in one.

The organisers claimed that it was the first-of-its-kind competition organised in Nepal.

Kathford College's Botmine Group A and Group B secured the first and second positions in the football competition. They bagged a cash prize of Rs. 20,000 and Rs. 10,000 respectively.

"The programme was organised to create a platform for students to showcase their knowledge and abilities in the sector of information and technology," said Bikal Baral, head of the computer and electrical education department in the college.

The programme also covered sectors like transportation, education, health, tourism, agriculture, rural development, alternative energy, cyber security, risk management, finance and Artificial Intelligence among others.

"Such programmes create a place where students with similar interests can share knowledge and experience for development and innovation. We need to invest more in the technical sector in the digital age," said Niraj Bohora, the lecturer and head of the department M.Sc. in Transportation Engineering.

NC central committee meeting kicks off

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

The Central Working Committee meeting of the ruling Nepali Congress kicked off at the party's central office, Sanepa in Lalitpur, on Thursday.

In the meeting chaired by party President Sher Bahadur Deuba, party General Secretary Bishwo Prakash Sharma presented the agendas of the meeting while another General Secretary, Gagan Kumar Thapa, presented the report relating to the NC's latest campaign.

Likewise, Joint General Secretary Jeevan Pariyar presented the report on the Jajarkot earthquake and the NC's activities like the rescue relief works.

Sharma proposed the agendas including the party's organisational activities, preparation for the Mahasamiti meeting, the National Reconciliation Day and others. He also informed about the National Assembly election candidate selection processes and other issues.

In the meeting, CWC members Dilendra Prasad Badu, Krishna Chandra Nepali Pokharel, Deepak Giri, Meen Bahadur Bishwokarma, Mohan Bahadur Basnet, Devendra Raj Kandel, Dr. Dila Sangraula, Karna Bahadur Budha, Rajib Koirala, Nain Singh Mahar, Mukta Kumari Yadav, Rangamati Shahi, Madan Krishna Shrestha, Bharat Kumar Shah and Sitadevi Yadav expressed their views, informed NC chief secretary Krishna Prasad Paudel in an official statement issued after the meeting. The next meeting of the CWC is scheduled for Friday at 11.00 am.

The party said it would not obstruct the reshuffling of the cabinet if the Prime Minister wanted to do so.

After the meeting, NC publicity department chief Meen Bahadur Bishwokarma told journalists that the Prime Minister could change ministers by consulting with the ruling coalition parties' leaders.

"The Prime Minister has the right to change the ministers. The parliamentary system is the prime ministerial system. If the Prime Minister feels it is necessary to change ministers, he can change them any time by consulting with top leaders of the ruling parties," Bishwokarma said.

In the meeting, the minister inducted in the government from the NC started to brief their performance.

On the first day, Health Minister Mohan Bahadur Basnet briefed his performance in the meeting.

No chance of rainfall till 2023 year-end: Met office

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

Is it going to rain? Many denizens were heard asking their neighbours looking at the cloudy sky on Thursday afternoon. But meteorologists predicted otherwise. The Meteorological Forecasting Division under the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology (DHM) said that the cloud condition was because of the partial impact of the westerly disturbance.

There is no chance of rainfall this year's winter, it predicted.

Kathmandu has remained surprisingly warm even at the end of December this year. On Thursday, the minimum temperature in Kathmandu was recorded at 7.8 degrees Celsius, and the maximum temperature reached 19.5 degrees Celsius, higher than previous years' temperature.

According to Gobinda Jha, Senior Meteorologist at the Meteorological Forecasting Division, the sky will be partially cloudy on Friday and Saturday but it will be clear in the evenings.

"However, there is still no chance of rainfall soon as the country has no notable weather system to bring precipitation," Jha added.

On Friday, the sky above the hilly regions of Koshi, Bagmati, and Gandaki provinces will remain partially cloudy while the rest of the areas are expected to remain generally clear, he said.

Jumla recorded the lowest temperature on Thursday at minus 4.5 degrees Celsius.

'Regional forums helpful...

The areas of BIMSTEC cooperation have been restructured into seven sectors of cooperation, with each member country taking a leading role in one area.

Out of the restructured areas like trade and investment, agriculture, tourism, climate change, security, science and technology, people-to-people relations, Nepal is leading the people-to-people relations sector.

FM Saud said that he participated in the BIMSTEC Foreign Ministerial Retreat held in Bangkok, Thailand in July this year. On that occasion, the foreign ministers of the seven BIMSTEC member countries collectively expressed their commitment to develop BIMSTEC as a strong organisation.

"In order to further strengthen and institutionalize BIMSTEC, an Eminent Persons' Group (EPG) of nine eminent persons has been formed to offer suggestions regarding the course of action to be taken by the BIMSTEC in the future to make cooperation and collaboration more effective," he said.

The suggestions of the EPG are expected to make BIMSTEC more dynamic, result-oriented and effective.

PMO to slash 68 staff...

Similarly, the Cabinet meeting decided to appoint Mahesh Bhattarai as the Member Secretary of the Council for Technical Education and Vocational Training (CTEVT), Sanothimi, Bhaktapur.

The post of the Member Secretary in the CTEVT was laying vacant after the compulsory retirement of Jeeb Narayan Kafle.

A three-member recommendation committee chaired by National Planning Commission member Ramesh Chandra Poudel recommended Tek Bahadur Malla, Director of National Skill Test, and Binod Badal, Head of Quality Project, along with Mahesh Bhattarai for the post of Member Secretary.

Likewise, the government has fixed the minimum support price of wheat at Rs. 3,650 per quintal. Minister Sharma, who is also the government spokesperson, said that the minimum support price of wheat fixed this year was more by Rs. 3 per kg than last year.

Last year, the government had fixed the support price of wheat at Rs 3,351 per quintal, and that cost Rs. 33.51 per kg. This year, it will cost Rs. 36.5 per kg.

Human issues involved in Yeti...

And the report concludes that the most probable cause of January's tragedy was "the inadvertent movement of both condition levels to the feathered position in flight." This movement, the document states, "resulted in the feathering of both propellors and subsequent loss of thrust," and led to "an aerodynamic stall and collision with terrain."

However, this "cause" did not bring the aeroplane down in isolation. The report highlights six factors that contributed to the accident that occurred on the day the country was celebrating Maghe Sankranti.

The first factor, the Commission has noted, was a high workload caused by operating in a new airport with surrounding terrain, and the crew missing the associated flight deck and engine indications that showed that both propellers had been feathered. The "new airport" mentioned here means the Pokhara International Airport (PIA), which was only inaugurated two weeks before the crash. The plane impacted the ground when it was on its final approach to PIA's Runway 12.

Human issues such as high workload and stress appear to have caused the crew members to misidentify and put the propellers in the feathered position. This high workload may have been the result of the proximity of terrain that required a tight circuit to land on Runway 12. "This tight circuit was not the usual visual circuit pattern and also meant that the approach did not meet the stabilised visual approach criteria," the investigators found.

Another element that pushed the airplane into mishap was the use of a visual approach circuit for Runway 12 without any evaluation, validation and resolution of its threats. These threats, the Commission brings up in the report, had been highlighted by the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal's Safety Risk Management team. The visual approach circuit had also been conducted without development (by the operator Yeti Airlines) and approval (by the regulator the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal) of the necessary chart.

The flight crew also lacked the appropriate technical and skill-based training, including simulator, and proper classroom briefings for a safe visual approach to Runway 12, the report states, while identifying non-compliance with standard operating procedures, ineffective crew resource management and lack of cockpit discipline as other contributing factors.

Quake victims queue up for temporary housing fund

BY BASHUDEV SHARMA
Jajarkot, Dec. 28

Rush of locals has increased in the banks and municipalities in Jajarkot district after the government sent subsidies to the earthquake victims to build temporary houses.

The beneficiaries flocked to the banks after the government sent Rs. 25,000, the first tranche of the subsidy of Rs. 50,000, in the account of the Local Disaster Management Committee to the victims, who are now living under tarpaulins.

After the money deposited in the District Disaster Management Fund was sent to the municipality's account, the beneficiaries have been queuing up in the banks to get the money.

According to Harish Chandra Sharma, Information Officer and Administrative Officer of Jajarkot District Administration Office, the local government sent the details of the beneficiaries entitled to receive the government subsidy to build the temporary housing and deposited the amount in the municipality's account.



Leaders and cadres of the Nepali Congress, CPN-UML, Maoist Centre, CPN-Biplav, their sister organisations and the government have constructed 6,056 temporary shelters in the earthquake-affected areas.

The District Disaster Management Fund has released Rs. 849.5 million for the 35,140 beneficiaries, and of them, 17,577 beneficiaries have been contracted for temporary accommodation, according to Sharma.

Of the total contract-signed beneficiaries, 8,114 beneficiaries have received Rs. 202.8 million as of Wednesday.

Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal
Aerodrome Engineering Department
Sinamangal, Kathamndu

Invitation for Bids (IFB)

(First date of Publication 2080/09/13)

Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN), Aerodrome Engineering Department (AED) invites electronic bids from all Nepalese eligible bidders for the construction of the following works under National Competitive Bidding procedures. Bids shall be submitted online within 1200 hours NST, 14th of Magh, 2080 using the online portal of www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp. Bids shall be opened in the presence of Bidder's representatives who choose to attend at 14:00 hours 14th of Magh, 2080 at the office of the Director.

S.N.	Location of the Project	Name of the Work	Contract Identification Number	Procurement Method	Price of Bid Document including VAT (NRs.)	Bid Security Amount Required (NRs.)	Estimated Amount (Including P.S. Excluding VAT & Contingency)
1.	Jomsom Airport	Construction of Chainlink Fence and Other Associated Works at Jomsom Airport.	CAAN/AED/JMO/Fencing/080-81/01	NCB: Single Stage Single Envelope	3,390.00	280,000.00	9,324,673.53
2.	Tumlingtar Airport	Construction of Security Chainlink fence and Other Associated works at Tumlingtar Airport.	CAAN/AED/TMI/Fencing/080-81/02	NCB: Single Stage Single Envelope	3,390.00	280,000.00	9,167,574.78
3.	CAA, Sanothimi	Construction of fire building, bathroom for security guard and associated works at CAA.	CAAN/AED/CAA/Fire Bldg/ 080-81/03	NCB: Single Stage Single Envelope	3,390.00	170,000.00	6,024,926.65
4.	Nalinchowk	Construction of basic passenger and security facility Building at Nalinchowk.	CAAN/AED/Nalinchowk/Bldg/080-81/04	NCB: Single Stage Single Envelope	3,390.00	140,000.00	5037066.32

Interested bidders can download the bidding documents from www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp. Bidders are required to follow the electronic bid submission procedure as specified in e-GP system operating Guidelines 2074 and user manuals issued by PPMO related to e-GP system from the website.

Baglung youth working to preserve Hanuman Dance



BY THAKUR ACHARYA
Baglung, Dec. 28

Youths of Baglung district have been active in preserving the Hanuman dance, which is popular in the Newar community. Performing the Hanuman dance is an old practice in the Newar community of Baglung.

In recent years, the Hanuman dance has been performed at fairs and festivals after the youth joined hands for the protection of indigenous art and culture by learning the dancing skills.

In the 7th Baglung Festival which started on Thursday, the youth went around Baglung Bazaar performing the Hanuman. President Ramchandra Paudel, who was in Baglung to inaugurate the festival, also watched the Hanuman dance with interest. Many observed the performance with keen interest when a group of young people dressed as Hanuman, the monkey god, danced in the market areas.

Hanuman dance is performed along the rhythm of cymbals and *mridangas*. The spectators were enthralled seeing nine pairs of artists disguised as Hanuman dancing with sticks to the rhythm of the music and passing through the market.

Yuvraj Rajbhandari, Vice Chairman of Hanuman Dance Conservation Council, Baglung, said that even though the Hanuman dance was supposed to be performed only after puja rituals, it was showcased to the guests who arrived in Baglung to attend the festival.

Tirtha Shrestha, Chairman of the Hanuman Dance Conservation Council, Baglung, said that the responsibility of preserving art and culture has fallen on the shoulders of the young generation. "It is our responsibility to preserve our old art," said Shrestha, "The responsibility of preserving our art culture now falls on the shoulders of the youth. Hanuman dance is our cultural identity. Considering the necessity to preserve it and pass it on to the next generation, we are regularly conducting training and educating the younger generation about the unique dance," added Shrestha.

Rajbhandari informed that the fairs and festivals, which were regularly organised, have helped transfer the glory, and importance of dance to the new generation.

"Youths aged between 12 and 14 years participated in the Hanuman dance," he said.

Rajbhandari said that the Hanuman dance requires a group of around 80 to 100 people including artists, musicians, priests, chiefs and managers.

The participation of the youths shows that the new generation is showing interest in learning and preserving Hanuman dance, he added.



PHOTO: CHANDRA PANDAK

Artists performing Chyambrung dance on the occasion of Chasok Tangnam festival in Taplejung.

FDB urges cinema halls to renew their licenses

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

The Film Development Board (FDB) has requested the cinema halls to operate them only after renewing their licenses.

Issuing a public notice on Thursday, the board informed the cinema houses operating throughout Nepal to function only after obtaining a license from the board and renewing it within the specified time.

The notification states that movie theatres operating in all provinces should acquire a license from the Film Development Board as provisioned in the Film Production, Exhibition, and Distribution Act, 2026, and the Film Production, Exhibition, and Distribution Regulation, 2057.



The board has requested the submission of updated license documents for the exhibition of movies and films within 35 days from the date of notice publication.

The notification mentions that legal action will be taken against the movie houses which fail to submit the required paperwork within the period.

Ojha honoured with UPAA Award in India

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28



Saroj Ojha, the presenter and director of the Sachetana Programme on NTV News, was honoured with the 'UPAA Award 2023' by the Uttar Pradesh Artist Academy of India recently.

He was honoured in the 30th edition of the award for his contribution to the field of communication.

According to the organisers, Ojha has been active in the production of television programmes including print and online media for the past two decades.

In previous editions, actors and filmmakers including Anil Kapoor, Raveena Tandon, Abbas Mastan, Sameer Anjan, Farooq Sheikh, Bhagyashree, Rahul Roy and cricketer Piyush Chawla had received the 'UPAA Award'.

Ojha has also been involved in the production and broadcasting of 'Bal Awaaz', 'Business Info', 'Namaste Nepal', 'Pravasi Ko Sandesh', 'Adarsh Parivar', the first cooking reality show in Nepal 'College Chef Icon', and the comedy tele-serial 'Kura Matra Bho', apart from ongoing Sachetana Programme. He has been working on documentaries as well as script writing and direction.

He also received 'Dadasaheb Phalke Award 2023' in Mumbai, and Human Rights Award 2023 in Lucknow. Also, he had bagged 'UNP-KFC Humanitarian Award' from the United Nations Peacekeepers Federal Council headquartered in Thailand in 2021 and 'MSN Excellence Award' in Egypt in 2019.

Shakira's hometown unveils a giant statue of the beloved Colombian pop star

AP
Colombia, Dec. 28

Pop star Shakira was immortalized in her Colombian hometown of Barranquilla, where officials unveiled a giant bronze statue of the music diva known around the world for her catchy tunes and exhilarating moves.

The six-meter (20-feet) tall monument depicts the multiple Grammy and Latin Grammy winner in one of her famous belly dancing outfits, with her hips swaying to her right and her arms raised gracefully toward the sky.

A plaque under the statue says that on Feb. 2, 1977, the town of "Barranquilla and the world witnessed the birth of a heart that composes, hips that don't lie, a voice that moves masses and a pair of bare feet that walk for the good of children and humanity." The statue, located on a recently built promenade along the Magdalena River that runs along the edge of the town, was unveiled in a small ceremony on Tuesday attended by Shakira's parents and the mayor, Jaime Pumarejo.

However, the bronze giant is not the Caribbean town's first Shakira statue. In 2006, Barranquilla unveiled a Shakira monument that depicts the pop star in her early days, playing an acoustic guitar and wearing jeans and boots. That statues stands near the entrance of the local soccer stadium.

Prakash Dutraj to perform in Nepalgunj



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Dec. 28

Renowned singer Prakash Dutraj, currently enjoying immense popularity, is set to entertain the audience in Nepalgunj during the upcoming 'New Year's Eve'. The event, organised to welcome the New Year 2024, promises a spectacular performance by singer Dutraj, known for hits like 'Remai', 'Choli Mailo Bho', Baini Jhyalaiima' 'Ghar Kata Ho Bainiko', and 'Lahur Jaane Relaiima'.

Keshav Neupane, the Director of Siddharth Group of Hospitality, an organiser of the programme, expressed excitement about featuring Prakash's new song 'Remai,' which recently gained popularity in western Nepal.

HOROSCOPE

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0ARIES: The further you go, the more pleasure you can find. Alluring Venus is entering your 9th House of Expansion, reminding you that there are countless amazing experiences available in this world.

CANCER: It's not your imagination if life swiftly settles into much smoother progress than usual. Gentle Venus is stepping into your 6th House of Routine, and will be doing everything. it can to iron out any wrinkles.

LIBRA: It's the perfect day to hit the town. Your ruler Venus is sashaying into your 3rd House of Communications, giving you an extra special gift of gab that everyone else is sure to notice.

CAPRICORN: Get ready to clear your plate. Venus is slipping into your 12th House of Endings, which is a rather quiet place for this pleasing planet to be dancing through.

TAURUS: Cosmic rewards should be in store very soon. Venus is entering your 8th House of Shared Finances, which can bring windfalls into your life when you least expect them.

LEO: It's your time to shine! Venus is dancing into your 5th House of Inspiration, making it nearly impossible to hide your light from the world. Instead, use this transit to put yourself forward, front.

SCORPIO: You deserve to enjoy the fruits of your labor. Venus, the planet of pleasure, is entering your 2nd House of Material Wealth, a sector Venus feels quite at home in.

AQUARIUS: Your social circles presently have much to offer! There's never been a better time to circulate as Venus enters your 11th House of Social Networks.

GEMINI: Productive relationships are the order of the day. As the sign of the Twins, you're in your element as Venus enters your 7th House of Social Connections.

VIRGO: Party at your place, Virgo! Fun-loving Venus is entering your 4th House of Shelter, bringing its joy and bounty right to your front door. This transit creates an ideal environment for any redecorating.

SAGITTARIUS: No one can deny your special flare. This new glow is thanks to alluring Venus arriving in your open-hearted sign for her annual visit, transforming you into one of the most enticing signs of the zodiac.

PISCES: You can practically do no wrong in the eyes of influential people. This glowing reputation is thanks to beautifying Venus entering your 10th House of Ambition.

CARTOON

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10-men Lalitpur beat Pokhara to fix final date with Dhangadhi

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN
Kushal Deuba of Lalitpur City FC celebrates after scoring a second goal against Pokhara Thunders FC during the Qualifier 2 match at the Nepal Super League at Dashrath Stadium, Kathmandu on Thursday.

Lalitpur City Football Club (LCFC), which was reduced to 10 men in the 34th minute, won the match against Pokhara Thunders FC (PTFC) to book its place in the finals of the second season of the Nepal Super League.

Imoh Ezekiel and Kushal Deuba netted one goal each to fix Lalitpur's title showdown with Dhangadhi FC on December 30.

Lalitpur's Nikhil S. Kadam was shown the second yellow card in the 34th minute after his kick found the legs of Ayush Ghalan. However, despite Kadam, a backbone of LCFC's midfield, sent off, Lalitpur found the way to continue its hope to win the league.

Pokhara was expected to intensify pressure on Lalitpur after it was restricted to 10 men; Lalitpur proved it otherwise.

After the red card to Kadam, Papa Ibou Kebe, one of Lalitpur's striker, was called behind the halfway line to strengthen the defence leaving striker Imoh Ezekiel in the front alone. The step became beneficial as a long pass by Kebe from Lalitpur's own half was found by Imoh to score the first goal of the match in the injury time of the first half.

Pokhara was seen stronger in the beginning of the second half. Yet, it was not easy for the players to get past a disciplined defence line of Lalitpur, left alone beating goalkeeper Jeffery Baltus.

Meanwhile, Pokhara got an equaliser in the 71st minute. Stephan K. Annor was able to head the ball off a cross by Joe Aidoo to the back of the net.

The equaliser helped Pokhara to prevent the loss in the 90 minutes of the match. Lalitpur was able to extend its lead and win the match in the extra time.

Kushal Deuba, who replaced Imoh before the end of the 90 minutes, became the super substitute as he scored the winning goal for Lalitpur. A freekick by Kareem Omolaja found Ananta Tamang outside the six-yard box, and Tamang headed it towards the goalpost.

However, three Pokhara defenders and goalie were unable to clear the header of Tamang properly allowing Deuba to score the second goal for the team.

Pokhara did not only struggle to create chances for a goal, the players could not capitalise on the difficultly created chances.

Lalitpur was seen determined to win the match despite a man down, and the team was able to fulfil its dream to play in the finals.

The match also saw over two dozen fouls and more than half-a-dozen yellow cards. Match official Nabindra Maharjan, who alone showed half-a-dozen yellow cards and the red to Kadam, was also replaced by referee Ram Darshan in the second-half.

Meanwhile, Lalitpur will have a greater challenge against Dhangadhi. Dhangadhi, which was the table topper in the league-stage, has been able to get a place in the finals consecutively. Dhangadhi lost the finals against Kathmandu Rayzrs FC in the first season of the NSL.

The winner of the second season of the NSL will be receiving a cash prize of Rs. 7 million, the organisers informed.

Koshi, Sudurpashchim, Bagmati qualify for playoffs with APF

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

With still one match day remaining, three others teams to play in the playoffs of the PM Cup Women's National Cricket Tournament 2080 with Armed Police Force (APF) Club have been decided on Thursday.

Koshi Province, Sudurpashchim Province and Bagmati Province will be playing in the playoffs as their points cannot be challenged even if the three teams lost in the final league-stage match on December 30.

Koshi, Madhes, APF and Bagmati registered wins in the matches against Sudurpashchim, Lumbini, Gandaki and Karnali on Thursday.

APF is still in the top with 12 points followed by Koshi (10 points). Sudurpashchim and Bagmati both have 8 points each and are in the top four.

Koshi chased the target of 119 posted by Sudurpashchim in 17.4 overs with two half centuries and won by eight wickets. Kajal Shrestha's 54 in 48 balls and Rubina Chhetry's not out knock of 51 off 55 balls helped Koshi score 122 in the loss of two wickets.

Madhes was able to snatch its second win of the tournament as they beat Lumbini by eight wickets. Madhes was given a target of 97 and the team reached it in 18.5 overs.

Lumbini was able to paste a target of at least 97 runs thanks to the not out knock of 64 off 64 balls by Laxmi Chaudhary. Puja Mahato remained not out for Madhes after scoring 60 runs in 59 balls.

Similarly, league topper and title-defender APF won its sixth consecutive match of the league against Gandaki by 52 runs. APF's bowlers Nary Thapa (4-18) and Sonu Khadka (2-14) restricted Gandaki at 75/7 in the end of 20 overs while chasing the target of 128.

On the other hand, Bagmati bagged the most comfortable win of Thursday as it won by 10 wickets against Karnali. Karnali could only paste a target of 43 as it was bowled out in 13.4 overs.

Khusi Dangol took four wickets by giving 18 runs while Sanskriti Phuyal took two wickets by giving four runs for APF.

Meanwhile, Lumbini (4 points), Madhes (4 points), Gandaki (2 points) and Karnali (0 points) cannot challenge either of the current top four for a place in the playoffs even if they win the match against Koshi, Karnali, Sudurpashchim and Bagmati on December 30 respectively.



DINESH, JAYRAM ENTER FINAL



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 28

Defending champion Dinesh Prajapati and Jayram Shrestha advanced to the final of the Surya Nepal NPGA Match Play, the second event under the Surya Nepal Golf Tour 2023-24, at the Royal Nepal Golf Club on Thursday.

Third seeded Dinesh defeated Rame Magar 3&2, while fourth seeded Jayram beat ninth seeded Bhuwan Kumar Rokka (1-up) on the final hole in the semi-final matches.

Dinesh was 2-up after first nine holes against Rame and he completed an easy victory with two holes remaining. Jayram was 1-up after nine holes but Bhuwan hit back to take one-hole lead after 15 holes.

Jayram bounced back to win the 16th and 17th holes to regain the lead and he emerged victorious after the players halved the final hole.

Dinesh and Jayram will contest in the 36-hole final on Friday, while Rame will take on Bhuwan in the 18-hole match to decide third place.

Man City rally for 3-1 win at Everton

AP
London, Dec. 28

Trailing 1-0 to Everton at halftime, Manchester City didn't much look like the newly crowned Club World Cup champion despite the new golden FIFA badge on the front of the players' shirts.

But Pep Guardiola had a simple message to his players at the break.

"The manager (told us) at halftime to just keep believing, we haven't got this badge for no reason," City midfielder Phil Foden said. "In the second half, yeah, wow, I think we blew them away with the way we played."

Foden started the comeback by equalizing in the 53rd minute, before Julian Alvarez's penalty and a late goal by Bernardo Silva secured a 3-1 win at Everton to put the defending champions back into the Premier League's top four.

The trip to Saudi Arabia for the Club World Cup was perhaps a bit of a distraction and allowed rivals Liverpool and Arsenal to widen the gap at the top. But City now can now fully refocus on the task of winning an unprecedented fourth straight Premier League title, and this was a vital first step in showing that it can't be counted out despite a recent poor run of form.

City is five points behind leader Liverpool with a game in hand, while Arsenal can go six points ahead of Guardiola's team by beating West Ham on Thursday.

"We know after six games with just one win, the people were asking, which is normal because it is all about results," Guardiola said about his team's recent run. "I have a feeling this team, we're going to be there."



Chelsea gets rare home win

League victories at Stamford Bridge have been hard to come by for Chelsea in 2023. But its last home game of the year ended in a 2-1 win over Crystal Palace after substitute Noni Madueke converted a late penalty for the hosts.

It was just Chelsea's sixth home league win of the calendar year, and Mauricio Pochettino's team once again struggled to turn possession into goals for much of the game. With Chelsea fielding the club's youngest ever starting lineup for a Premier League game — thanks to a slew of injuries and suspensions — the Blues took the lead through Mykhailo Mudryk in the 13th minute. But the hosts missed several chances to double their advantage before Michael Olise equalized just before the break.

Just as it looked like Chelsea's inefficiency up front would cost it again, Madueke was tripped by Eberechi Eze inside the area and stepped up to the spot himself to send goalkeeper Dean Henderson the wrong way in the 89th minute.

That lifted Chelsea into 10th place, which is still far from where the club had expected to be at this stage when it hired Pochettino at the end of last season.

Brentford's collapse

Brentford might need to start worrying about a relegation scrap.

Thomas Frank's team fell to a sixth loss in seven games after making a couple of defensive howlers in a 4-1 home defeat against Wolverhampton.

South Korea forward Hwang Hee-chan scored twice as Wolves took full advantage of Brentford's mistakes, including one that came straight after the kickoff following the visitors' opening goal. Nathan Collins' back pass to goalkeeper Mark Flekken was under-hit, allowing Hwang to round him and tap into an empty net barely 10 seconds after the restart.

Marsh's 96 leads Australia fightback



AFP
Melbourne, Dec. 28

Mitchell Marsh hit a counter-attacking 96 in a fighting rescue mission with a dogged Steve Smith Thursday to help Australia build a 241-run lead and regain control of the second Test against Pakistan.

The hosts were reeling at 16-4 after dismissing Pakistan for 264 in reply to their first innings 318 in Melbourne.

But Marsh and Smith put their heads down to compile what could be a match-saving 153-run partnership.

At stumps on day three, the hosts were 187-6 with Smith out for 50, off 176 balls, in the last over of the day, leaving Alex Carey unbeaten on 16.

Shaheen Shah Afridi and Mir Hamza both took three wickets.

It could have been a different story but Abdullah Shafique spilled a regulation catch in the slips when Marsh was on 20.

Marsh eventually fell four runs short of a deserved century, but it took a superb one-handed diving catch at slip from Agha Salman to remove him.

After Cummins took 5-48 and Nathan Lyon 4-73 to dismiss Pakistan, Australia needed to negotiate a tricky 15 minutes of the morning session.

But Usman Khawaja was out for a duck second ball, caught behind by Mohammad Rizwan off bowling spearhead Afridi.

The same combination struck again when Marnus Labuschagne edged down the legside on five as the hosts slumped to 6-2 at lunch. When they returned, David Warner let rip with a drive to the boundary off Afridi, but he didn't last, dragging a Mir Hamza ball on to his stumps on six.

He received a standing ovation as he walked off for the last time as a batsman at the Melbourne Cricket Ground, with the third Test in Sydney set to be the last of his long career.

Things got worse for the hosts when Travis Head was bowled by Hamza's inswinging yorker next delivery to leave Australia in disarray at 16-4.

But Marsh saw off the hat-trick ball and along with Smith dug in to take the sting out of the attack.

When Aamer Jamal came on, Marsh slammed three boundaries in four balls to further relieve the pressure before the missed chance by Abdullah.

Smith played a crucial supporting role, taking 101 balls for his first boundary before reaching a gritty 40th Test half-century.

Pakistan had begun the day on 194-6, after an electric spell from Cummins in the final session on Wednesday saw a collapse from 124-1, and the Australia skipper was again in the thick of the action.

Rizwan made a confident start, adding 13 to his overnight 29.

WEATHER

Friday

Sunrise at 6:54 am, Sunset at 5:18 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Friday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas and partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 18 - 20°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Thursday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.8	5.0	0.0
Dipayal	24.3	7.5	0.0
Dhangadi	22.3	10.2	0.0
Birendranagar	23.9	6.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	23.6	10.6	0.0
Jumla	17.1	-4.5	0.0
Ghorahi	22.8	9.4	0.0
Pokhara	22.5	10.7	0.0
Bhairahawa	25.9	10.4	0.0
Simara	26.2	10.6	0.0
Kathmandu	18.9	7.8	0.0
Okhaldhunga	16.6	8.8	0.0
Taplejung	15.2	8.4	0.0
Dhankuta	23.5	9.5	0.0
Biratnagar	28.0	12.5	0.0
Jomsom	10.1	-5.5	0.0*
Dharan	27.9	15.0	0.0*
Lumle	15.5	8.5	0.0*
Janakpur	29.5	12.8	0.0*
Jiri	15.0	3.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 29, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.77	Rs. 133.37
Euro	1	Rs. 147.67	Rs. 148.33
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.85	Rs. 170.61
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 158.73	Rs. 159.45
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.76	Rs. 91.17
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.45	Rs. 100.90
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.84	Rs. 101.30
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.43	Rs. 9.48
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.69	Rs. 18.77
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.40	Rs. 35.56
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.47	Rs. 36.63
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.89	Rs. 3.91
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.15	Rs. 36.31
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.82	Rs. 28.95
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.32	Rs. 10.36
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.37	Rs. 13.43
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.81	Rs. 19.90
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.99	Rs. 17.06
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.38	Rs. 434.33
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.17	Rs. 353.76

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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